

**Budget Hearing
June 1, 2021
Via zoom
Meeting notes**

Introduction: Mayor Lungo-Koehn: 7:05 PM

Melanie McLaughlin: Roll

Jenny Graham, Kathy Kreatz, Melanie McLaughlin, Mea Mustone, Paul Ruseau, Paulette Van der Kloot, Mayor Lungo-Koehn: 7 present, 0 absent

Pledge of Allegiance

Dr. Edouard-Vincent: I am pleased to report that this is our 8th meeting on the budget process. Mr. Murphy will explain the steps that were taken. Thanks to Mr. Murphy, Michelle Kingdon and the team who have put so much effort into putting this together.

Dave Murphy: Thanks to Michelle Kingdon and all the department heads for helping to pull together all the materials.

Dave Murphy: Presentation on screen

Purpose of the meeting is to put forth a final budget that will be approved by the School Committee.

Recommendation: 68.2 million dollars ask from municipal government

School dept. Concurrent responsibilities: represent the needs of the district as to what will benefit the students of Medford: \$68.2 m

Second concurrent responsibility: \$67.2 m to run the district with whatever is appropriated to the school department. We are prepared to operate the district with whatever is appropriated. We have been transparent and communicative with the community. The other issue is that federal funding is allowing us to pursue priorities that are at the nexus of our needs. We don't want to create structural deficits that are unsustainable at our current pace. I am not suggesting that this investment represents fundamental change in funding. It is an honest request based on realistic parameters. After you make this request to the municipal government and they make appropriation, we will present a revised budget that scales back as necessary. We will then have a clearer sense of what the ESSER budget provides to us.

Mayor Lungo-Koehn: We were all delivered our budget books on Friday. Are there any comments or questions from SC or the Community?

Paul Ruseau: will our requests be the line items in the budget?

Dave Murphy: Our request is \$68.2 m. if it is less than that, then our revised budget will reflect that smaller amount in addition to the ESSER funding. There are two schools of thought with regards to ESSER; 1. It is a relief to municipal governments 2. School districts have incurred disproportionate expenses due to the pandemic and therefore ESSER should be walled off and used to fund those expenses.

Hard to separate the two: There have been increased expenses for schools but it is impossible to wall off priorities and say they are COVID specific. The social emotional needs will be long term needs. We will use the operating budget to support our needs. We have a good sense of what will go to ESSER and what will go to the operating budget.

Paul Ruseau: I have a question about transportation: up \$50K. I don't see any money related to money for high school buses.

Dave Murphy: the \$50K is the automatic increase. By repurposing some buses and taking a closer look at the bus routes, we can look to expand yellow bus capacity at the high school. We are in the process now of accumulating the data we need to determine how to expand the transportation option to accomplish the goal of the SC to better service the high school students. Our vendor Eastern Bus is aware that we may want to expand our yellow bus capacity in the next year.

Jenny Graham: Anything listed in the tables with a TBD is something we should not expect to see in the beginning of the 2021/2022 school year.

Dave Murphy: TBDs in the long term priorities column - yes probably true. If the municipal government were to appropriate the requested budget, we may be able to do that but most likely the TBDs are long term priorities that were presented to the school committee as goals but not necessities. We are trying to collect more data on whether it is possible.

Jenny Graham: \$852K for infrastructure requirements - are they part of the \$68 million ask?

Dave Murphy: For the most part no, but ideally it would stay on the capital side of the ledger. There are tech. Infrastructure when it comes to access points, security and archiving that could be considered an annual maintenance cost. All of the heavy infrastructure (generators, security cameras, boiler at Curtis Tufts) will use current cap. Support.

Jenny Graham: High School renovations? Bathrooms, caron theater, snow removal?

Dave Murphy: Not in the \$68.2M.

Jenny Graham: Elementary School: building based literacy and math coach positions: long term budget priorities

Dave Murphy: Included in the \$68.2 million budget. This is an opportunity to explain the contingencies based on the appropriation we are given. The SC gave long term priorities they hoped were to be included in this budget proposal. We did include it in this proposal but the admin has been clear and candid as to what our priorities are and how to best structure. If the appropriation is less than we request, the coaching positions will most likely not be included in our final ask. Coaches would be an excellent investment but going from 0 to 8 is not necessarily something we can do to the standards we would want to achieve. I do not anticipate that they would be high priorities.

Jenny Graham: Sticking with half a librarian for each elementary school.

Dave Murphy: Currently embedded in the instructional technology department. I don't anticipate a significant increase in library staffing but there are short term needs due to expanded technology. The structure of those departments leads to some challenges. There are staff that should be focused on the library but need to focus on tech. We may need to use ESSER funding to address the Tech side to alleviate some issues on the library side. We want more support in the libraries. There is more untangling that has to happen.

Kathy Kreatz: How will the costs associated with the repairs we discussed in B&G last Wednesday be paid for?

Dave Murphy: They are all in the capital budget line. Some from previous projects/capital funds. Specific to the generator/boiler/ one other one. Hot water heater is in active discussion right now.

Kathy Kreatz: When will we get the appropriation from the City Government. Usually we know what the number is going into the last hearing?

Mayor Breanna Lungo-Koehn: We still have interim guidance on ARPA. I am trying to do everything I can to make it a reality for our students and faculty.

Dave Murphy: We have been having very collaborative conversations but at the same time, we are making a recommendation so that the School Committee can achieve its responsibilities and make the request. It is the case that the other departments don't have to present their needs in a public forum. We will build out the ESSER budget that will include summer priorities and other post pandemic needs. It won't be after June 30. We can present it to you based on what we know is being recommended along with proposed ESSER funding - the week of June 21st.

Paulette Van der Kloot: We spoke at length about the transportation for high school students. I thought about whether students could still buy MBTA bus passes?

Dave Murphy: I would recommend that we leave that option available. The discounted pass is a benefit we don't want to provide them of even if we don't want to make it their only way of getting to school.

Paulette Van der Kloot: Going down a bus is a big surprise to me - we need to keep our budgeting generous in this area. It is hard to take back what was given before. There are many positives in this budget: French at the 6th grade level; text books in the Science area: there are major upgrades in many areas. I am concerned about some areas such as Fine Arts: i have been advocating for a Director of Fine Arts. I feel this area is very critical in the social emotional way of life. I will watch this carefully. I was surprised not to see increased numbers of ukuleles and violins? Some other things for summer enrichment? Is this coming from ESSER?

Dave Murphy: Yes from Esser. The reason the instruments are not identified yet is we need more details on exactly how much we need to increase the instrument stock. I feel it can be absorbed in another area. There could be 50 other things of a similar nature that we can't specify right now. If we are going to determine that the extended school day initiatives based on the arts will require more instruments, we will be able to absorb it in other parts of the budget at the start of the fiscal year.

Paulette Van der Kloot: Part of my real is violin and the orchestra program. There are some things that are germane to students enjoying school.

Dave Murphy: It is an important illustration of something that is not specifically called out but that the SC is concerned about. We can certainly make sure it is highlighted in our final presentation.

Paulette Van der Kloot: In the Math Department, it sets aside money for a math academy. Is this esser funds?

Dave Murphy: Yes. I mentioned that the \$68.2 is the money we landed at when we scrubbed the budget. We have further identified \$110k that could be in the operating budget but could also be covered by ESSER. That amount of movement is inevitable. We have spelled out line by line how the \$68.2 should be spent.

Melanie McLaughlin: thank you for all the work. In regards to the circuit breaker for special education, when does that get backed out?

Dave Murphy: The district is responsible for the students enrolled by April 1st. In regards, the numbers can fluctuate but during the summer we will have estimated projections. We have seen an enrollment decline. It has generally remained between \$1m and \$1.5m.

Melanie McLaughlin: Is there a reconciliation of those numbers?

Dave Murphy: I think it would be prudent to establish a quarterly process to update what funds are coming in for special education and what remains for the remainder of the fiscal year.

Melanie McLaughlin: I think a reconciliation process would be great. 1 to 1 aids for students with IEPs?

David Murphy:: there is a significant amount of funding to para staffing. Part of it is for the paras needed in a program at the Roberts School. The need for building based paras to not be connected to specific students but to be available for classroom support is there. One to one support is part of the fixed cost increases. That is a compliance based obligation that the district will take on.

Melanie McLaughlin: Bldg. Based Paras: we hear that paras are used as substitute positions in the school. Instructional tutor vs. regular para? Ms. Bowen?

David Murphy: Paras who are supporting students as part of the IEP is an obligation to the students. It is not sanctioned by the district. It may have happened very sparingly. These investments are not about pulling paras out of places where they need to be to service their students.

Melanie McLaughlin: All students are obligated to the least restrictive environment. Why are we going down in the substitute line item?

Dave Murphy: I suspect that the number is reflective of how we increased that budget when COVID money was coming in.

Melanie McLaughlin: It is actually a higher number.

Paul Ruseau; I hope that we can prioritize a fine arts director next year. We need to restore that. Last year we had a memo with a list of unmet needs. This big number is not as big as it looks. Last year we laid a lot of people off.

Dave Murphy: Either way we will update the memo.

Ms. Leticia Rocha: Mystic Valley Parkway: Question regarding transportation; will all high schoolers who live beyond 2 miles be guaranteed yellow bus transportation?

Dave Murphy: It is our intention to provide transportation to all beyond two miles

Leticia Rocha: MBTA is not reliable. I support one mile radius for high schoolers. This administration talks about equity. MBTA should not be the only option. I have two follow up questions: How will the data be gathered? When will we know if yellow buses will be available to high school students?

Dave Murphy: I agree that students outside a two mile radius having to buy mbta passes is unfair. We have to collect additional data to confirm the action plan. I am not paying lip service to equity. Every member of the SC and administration is not putting on a show and we will collect the appropriate data.

Melanie McLaughlin: Thanks Ms. Rocha for bringing this up. This has been an ongoing discussion for years. I am wondering if we can have a June 14 deadline on what those numbers are?

Dave Murphy: the sc renewed the Eastern contract last spring. I don't recommend we make this decision before we finish out the first year of the contract. I can give an update on June 14 but can't promise the numbers are solid.

Marice Edouard-Vincent : In order for us to get the information by June 14, it is not realistic. We have been given the charge by the committee and we will pursue reliable information. We need more time in order to do that.

Melanie McLaughlin: Can you give us a time frame so the community will know when to expect answers?

Dave Murphy: This is something that we will work on for the remainder of the school year and we need to meet with the vendor and identify the routes. It is our intention to have this prior to the start of the school year. It may have to be adjusted after the start of the school year. I am confident that one way or another, we will expand the transportation program. This is a complicated problem. We will come back to the SC to present how it will be done.

Melanie McLaughlin: When?

Dave Murphy: By the last week of August. I don't know.

Paul Ruseau: We did just pass a motion saying August 1.

Dave Murphy: You will have an update before August 1.

Paulette Van der Kloot: CCSR did a project on user fees.

Dave Murphy: It is waived for some but it brings in \$75k to \$95K in user fees.

Paulette Van der Kloot: We have taken great pains to make sure fees are waived for students who couldn't afford them. We should take this up again at a school committee meeting. We hoped to waive all user fees but it is always a budget impact. I would like to hear the student concerns.

Mea Mustone: Motion to accept the budget and put it forth to city council.

Kathy Kreatz/Paulette Van der Kloot; Second

Jenny Graham, Kathy Kreatz, Melanie McLaughlin, Mea Mustone, Paul Ruseau, Paulette Van der Kloot, Mayor Lungo-Koehn: 7 affirmative/0 negative motion passes

Motion to adjourn: Paulette Van der Kloot/Melanie McLaughlin

Jenny Graham, Kathy Kreatz, Melanie McLaughlin, Mea Mustone, Paul Ruseau, Paulette Van der Kloot, Mayor Lungo-Koehn; 7 affirmative/0 negative motion passes

Meeting adjourned at 8:31PM.